

From Rock Bottom to ‘Gradwaiting’: How One IT Student Fought Through Life’s Storms to Chase His Dream

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When people talk about success stories, they often skip the struggle. Individuals primarily state victorious moments, such as caps thrown into the air and diplomas held aloft in victory with an air of accomplishment; they rarely talk about the late nights spent gazing at a pile of work, on a cracked laptop, tired and hungry.

For Marco, a 22-year-old information technology major, such hardships were his daily life. “I came close to quitting. Not school—everything,” he confesses, his tone gentle but firm. “There were times when even getting up in the morning felt like a task.”

Growing up in a financially hard-pressed household, Marco was well aware that his path would be a difficult one. His parents, with two jobs to provide the necessities of their household, saw education as a means of escape. Marco clung to that vision, but there were times the weight of it snapped at him.

During his second year of college, things went from bad to worse. His dad lost his job. There were increasing financial obligations. Online learning during the pandemic worsened things—he lacked a reliable internet connection, had an old laptop, and felt increasingly alone. He had to work night shifts at a fast food restaurant near his house just to pay for his mobile data and course materials for his assignments. And the course itself? No walk in the park. “People think IT is just coding and playing with computers,” he says with a weary smile. “But it’s constant pressure. Technology changes fast. You blink, and what you just learned is already outdated.”

He once failed a basic programming course. It devastated him. The humiliation, the self-doubt—it almost ended his journey.

But then a turning point occurred.

A professor, seeing Marco's potential and perseverance, spoke with him privately. "You're not the best coder in the class," she said bluntly. "But your persistence is unmatched. This trait is more vital in the long run." That blunt validation fueled a fire in him. He started sticking around after class sessions to get things explained. He started participating in group coding exercises. He set out not just to survive but to succeed. Marco also thanks his close group of friends, who combined their funds and supported him through each test and meltdown. "Sometimes, it's not about having everything figured out," he says. "It's just about having people who won't let you drown."

Now in his last semester, Marco is contently "gradwaiting." He pronounces the word with a smile—half awe, half relief. "It means I've gotten this far. I'm not finished yet, but I can see the finish line."

His aspiration? To be a systems analyst. Marco's story isn't one of degree attainment alone. It's one of hope rather than despair, of resolve rather than defeat. He's a testament that the road to the finish line isn't always clean or fast—but it's always worth the trip.

And when he finally walks across that stage in his graduation gown, it won't just be a piece of paper he's receiving. Rather, it will be a victory years in the making.